a "totally biased vendetta", and invoking a proprietary right to the name and symbol.

But even as she ordered party workers to remove the blanket they had put on the familiar board outside her Kalighat home, her words in public presaged an interesting turn in tactics. In her first news conference since June, Mamata reached back into Indian political history: how Indira Gandhi had similarly struggled with election symbols, losing the 'two bullocks' in 1969, then the 'cow and calf' in 1978, settling on the 'palm', which has endured since. If that evoked the memory of a famous resurgence, Mamata also seems to be finding solace in the *abhayamudra*—the gesture of protection the palm proffers in Indian symbology. There's urgent context: the October 6 bypolls to five assembly seats, where the fight is not just symbolic.



PTI

Takeaways

- **EC bars TMC from original name, symbol. Mamata to fight it out legally, but caught in limbo**
- **Confusion in party over Oct. 6 bypolls. One candidate cries off, TMC partially backs Congress**
- **Elsewhere, the Mamata faction in the fray under new name, flag. Some say a full boycott is better**

THE CASUALTY WARD

On September 18, Mamata's Nandigram candidate Sanchita Pradhan Dey withdrew her nomination after meeting chief minister Suvendu Adhikari. Mamata then announced support for Congress candidate Milan Pradhan, saying she had spoken to Rahul Gandhi the previous night without disclosing her decision. The next day, the same uncertainty surfaced in Rejinagar. Mamata's candidate Rabiul Alam Chowdhury first announced he would withdraw, saying workers were "disoriented" without the symbol. Then, he U-turned. After a meeting with the cadre at the Beldanga police station—it was apparently not safe outside—Rabiul announced it thus: "Didi called me and motivated me to stay in the fight—so I shall, even if only 10 workers come with me."

The flip-flop didn't exactly spread cheer. Party spokesperson Kunal Ghosh posted a sharp critique on Facebook, which he deleted but apparently did not 'withdraw'. His argument: the party should have chosen not to contest at all under an interim identity and instead supported Congress candidates everywhere. "Only blaming Suvendu or BJP would not be right. They laid the trap. Why did we fall into their trap?" Kunal wrote. The strategy was wavering, he added, without internal discussions—Mamata, too, had earlier said transferring votes to the Congress could be a realistic course under such circumstances.

Indeed, Mamata has shown a warmth towards the Congress that was not very evident earlier—Rahul has reciprocated, backing her ownership of the TMC name and symbol. But right now, she's partially exposed to a risky contest without that familiar cover. It's an open question whether she can pull off the Indira Gandhi act. ■

▶ GOA

'Ekvott' Fractures Into Many

As AAP makes a third front with regional party GFP, Congress plan to have united front in tatters

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

CALL IT OLD PORT WINE IN A NEW BOTTLE. In 2017, a victory-bound Congress dithered on sharing space with local Goan parties—the disunity helped the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) convert its loss into a rigged-up machine assembled out of purloined parts picked up as if at a junkyard sale. In 2022, the Trinamool Congress was in meridian transit from east to west, living up to its 'All India' prefix. That vision sank into a Goan sunset. But not before the anti-BJP vote split in four cardinal directions—with the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) debuting as well. This time, a Congress plan to build a grand armada of Opposition parties doesn't look like floating either.

Chief cause: AAP and Vijai Sardesai's regionalist Goa Forward Party (GFP) have formed a third front for the 2027 assembly poll. It's called 'Goa First'. Sardesai left a door ajar for a larger anti-BJP front—fittingly, during a late September visit to the Ajmer dargah. If no one takes him up on that, the first thing Goa First may do is split the channels that could have jointly irrigated an Opposition watershed.

In August, visiting Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge had invoked the Konkani word for 'unity'—*ekvott*—which has the happy coincidence of sounding like the Hindi for 'one vote'.